

Chapter 71 Part 5

The cafeteria food was similar to school cafeterias, but tasted a bit better. There were three dishes and a soup, and you could choose whether you wanted rice, noodles, or steamed buns and baozi¹.

Liang Shi ate quickly. After finishing, she observed everyone sitting there. Those young-looking children acted very steadily, having gone through each procedure many times, and their faces showed a maturity beyond their years.

Liang Shi looked down at her account balance again—still over 200,000, nearly 300,000.

After the meal, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu prepared to leave. Gu Zhaoyuan saw them to the entrance.

Gu Zhaoyuan seemed apologetic. "I'm sorry I couldn't provide you with help."

"It's fine." Liang Shi said: "I saw many other things, and I'm very interested in your future project. If you want to establish a new orphanage, I'd be happy to help."

Gu Zhaoyuan was stunned. "Huh?"

Actually, from the moment these two said they wanted to consult about matters, he hadn't held any hope for them.

Every year, quite a few people came here to investigate things. They basically all came under the pretext of wanting to donate money or goods, but in the end, after looking around and not finding the results they wanted, they would leave and never again mention helping this place.

But Liang Shi said very sincerely: "Director Gu, give me your account number. I don't have much money on hand right now, but I can buy some clothes and things for the children here."

Gu Zhaoyuan was truly bewildered. "For the children?"

"Yes." Liang Shi said: "There are still many school-age students here, right? Buy them some clothes and such. Also, if any child is short on tuition and you're tight on funds, you can call me. I'll help them with the tuition fees. They must study hard."

After saying this, she smiled gently. "I won't take up any more of your time. Please give me your account number."

Gu Zhaoyuan took out his phone and entered a string of numbers. "This is our special donation account. When you donate, enter your name and email, as well as the purpose of the funds. After we implement it, we'll send you photos and an expense list to ensure your money was used on the people you intended it for."

This was essentially telling Liang Shi that her money wouldn't be embezzled by others, but would truly go to charity.

Liang Shi efficiently transferred 100,000 to him. "Winter is coming soon. Buy the children new winter coats."

After the transfer, Liang Shi added: "I noticed there's only a library for the elderly here, and not many books. Many children don't have books to read. If I have time this week, I'll send over a batch of books. Will you have time?"

"Yes." Gu Zhaoyuan was in a continued state of bewilderment and immediately said: "I'm here every day."

"Good." Liang Shi said: "I hope you can get the orphanage running again."

Gu Zhaoyuan seemed as energized as if he'd been injected with adrenaline² and smiled: "Definitely!"

After saying this, they bid farewell to Gu Zhaoyuan. But Gu Zhaoyuan suddenly called out to them: "Whose records are you looking for? Perhaps I can be of help."

Liang Shi paused, then shook her head. "This is my friend's privacy. I can't say. We came here just to try our luck."

"Then when you come next time, I'll take you to see my father." Gu Zhaoyuan said: "He might know something."

Liang Shi nodded and smiled. "Alright."

Standing to the side, Xu Qingzhu looked at Liang Shi, thinking that Liang Shi had quite a few methods for winning people's hearts—she was quite capable.

At first, Gu Zhaoyuan had clearly been perfunctory with them, always speaking in official platitudes.

But after Liang Shi did this, Gu Zhaoyuan looked at her with new eyes and was even willing to help arrange a meeting with the previous director.

Xu Qingzhu felt she was getting to know Liang Shi anew.

But Liang Shi hadn't thought that much. As they were about to leave, Liang Shi also left Gu Zhaoyuan her phone number.

She handed him a sticky note rather than choosing to exchange numbers with Gu Zhaoyuan.

She had also written her name on the sticky note.

After handing it over, Gu Zhaoyuan paused, then said: "Your wife has my contact information. If you want to come over, you can contact me in advance."

Liang Shi nodded: "Alright."

At the same time, Gu Zhaoyuan placed that sticky note in his wallet.

His wallet was leather, with worn edges—it looked like it had some age to it. Liang Shi only glanced at it casually, but after looking away, she was suddenly startled and immediately said: "Director Gu, is that photo in your wallet of you and your father?"

Gu Zhaoyuan nodded: "Mm, and my younger sister."

"Your younger sister?" Liang Shi frowned: "May I take a look?"

Gu Zhaoyuan was somewhat hesitant, but Liang Shi said: "I mean no harm. I just feel your sister looks very familiar, like I've seen her somewhere."

"She's already passed away." Gu Zhaoyuan smiled bitterly, but still carefully took out the photo tucked in the wallet compartment, saying with a trace of nostalgia: "You probably saw someone who looks a bit like her."

Liang Shi took the photo. Xu Qingzhu also leaned over to look, and was indeed startled at first glance.

The girl in this photo had facial features that were sixty percent similar to the middle school-aged Qi Jiao they had seen from Zhao Xuning.

You just needed to lift all her features upward a bit.

This type of facial structure was easy to adjust.

Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi looked at each other, both seeing shock in each other's eyes.

Liang Shi asked: "What was your sister's name?"

"Gu Xingyue³." Gu Zhaoyuan said: "She had a very withdrawn personality. She couldn't speak until she was seven. We all thought she was mute."

"May I politely ask when she passed away?" Liang Shi asked.

Gu Zhaoyuan smiled bitterly. "Not long after this photo was taken, she passed away. My father took her on a trip and they had a car accident."

"More specifically?" Liang Shi asked again.

"End of 2010⁴." Gu Zhaoyuan said: "She was 13 that year."

Liang Shi returned the photo to Gu Zhaoyuan. "I'm sorry, that was rude of me."

"It's fine." Gu Zhaoyuan said: "Thinking about it now, my father must have also been affected by my sister's death. You can only say it was from accumulated stress and fatigue."

Liang Shi didn't know how to comfort him, but Gu Zhaoyuan didn't need comforting either. He just said to them: "It's quite far to drive back to the city from here. You should leave soon. Be careful on the road."

Liang Shi nodded. "Alright."

Footnotes:

¹ Baozi (包子, bāozi): Chinese steamed buns typically filled with meat or vegetables, a common staple food in China.

² Adrenaline (literally "chicken blood" 雞血, jīxuè): A Chinese colloquial expression meaning to be energized or pumped up, similar to "pumped full of adrenaline" in English.

³ Gu Xingyue (古星月, Gǔ Xīngyuè): The name literally means "Ancient Star-Moon." "Xing" (星) means star and "Yue" (月) means moon. This name was given because she was found under the stars and moon, as explained in the text.

⁴ 2010: This is a crucial timeline detail. Qi Jiao jumped in summer 2010, and Gu Xingyue died in a "car accident" at the end of 2010—suggesting a connection between these two events.